

Curious Consumption, Controlled

Cocktails

The nights look the same, but the glass doesn't—Gen Z is curating its buzz rather than chasing it

BY SONALI

WHILE EYEING A table split between lager, Picante, and neon-green fizz, Vikas Narula, Co-founder of Depot48, thinks out loud: “They’re not ditching margaritas, they’re adding matcha and kombucha to the mix.” The man behind the culture-forward bar in the capital is speaking about Gen Z’s drinking habits. “They want range. It’s not a switch; it’s a spectrum.”

Narula’s hypothesis raises a pertinent question: Is this generation really sober, or are they just ‘multi-tasting?’

“If anything, they’re more curious and experimental,” adds Narula.

JUST SOBER-CURIOUS

By most measures, Gen Z really is rethinking its relationship with alcohol, even if they haven’t typically broken up with it. The trend

is global. According to market research company Circana’s 2025 “Sober Curious Nation” update, nearly two in three (65%) Gen Zers said that they planned to drink less in 2025, and roughly four in ten said they wanted a fully dry lifestyle.

The motivations are very personal. “I hate the physical aftermath—the vomiting, nausea, hangover,” says Sheya Kurian, a 27-year-old working in Delhi.

Health, money, and especially mental health dominate; a sizable Gen Z cohort reports going alcohol-free specifically to protect their anxiety, sleep, and productivity.

Salloni Ghodawat, CEO of Ghodawat Consumer Ltd, running the non-alcoholic beer brand Coolberg, reflects on this trend. “At the core of this movement is a profound shift in values. Indian youth are more health-conscious than ever before.” Rohan (name changed), a 26-year-old fitness enthusiast who quit drinking in 2022 to focus on

weight loss and workouts, says, “I’ve stayed sober since then and never looked back.”

Bacardi’s cocktail trends report, tracking global patterns for a spirits giant with a strong India footprint summarises the shift this way: “Gen Z isn’t drinking less, they’re simply drinking earlier, lighter, and with more intention.”

The *BT-PRICE Survey* shows that 10% of Gen Z consumes alcohol; 13% consume cigarettes only. It also highlights that 17% consume both.

FROM “MOCKTAIL” TO THE ZERO-PROOF ERA

If Gen Z is damp rather than dry, the no- and low-ABV category has been one of the earliest and clearest beneficiaries. According to an Invest India report, ‘*Seed to Sip-India’s rise as a hotspot for beverage investments*,’ India’s non-alcoholic beverages market will possibly reach \$88.25 billion in 2027, up from \$38.03 billion in 2022, a CAGR of 18.3%.